

CHAPTER ZERO

Rehoboam was galloping his horse swiftly through the streets of the kingdom. When he arrived at the palace's garden, he dismounted his horse and one of the nearest guards took hold of the reins, leading the prince's horse to the stable while the others opened the door for Rehoboam. This time, Rehoboam was dashing through the corridors of the palace.

“Father!” he exclaimed anxiously as he entered the throne room. “A portion of the army... They have rebelled believing that you are the one who has kept all the magical power to yourself! What should I do? Shall I have them killed before the rebellion grows even stronger?”

Elder Solomon, watching outside through the window, turned to his son. He brought his hand to his beard and began stroking it. “Dark magic has had a worse effect than I anticipated. Their desires may seem simple, but their demands will be endless. No matter how much power they possess, they will always crave more! However, we still haven't been able to cleanse the other realm. That's why, even with a slight chance, they might regain their senses. We will give them some time. Gather the people in the palace garden. Ensure their safety. And I want a wall from the soldiers. Let our loyal ones protect our people.”

“As you command,” Rehoboam said, then swiftly exited the throne room. Solomon took a deep breath and made his way towards his throne

CHAPTER ONE

The sunlight slowly entered through the window, illuminating the house. The woman with her brown hair scattered all over the pillow opened her eyes. She sat up slowly and got out of bed. She opened the partially drawn curtains all the way and looked outside. The man mowing the grass behind the fence saw the woman looking out the window. He furrowed his brows and cursed at her. With a sigh, the woman closed the curtains. She quickly changed her pajamas to sportswear and tied her hair back. She left her room and hurriedly descended the stairs. Then she went out through the door on the lower floor.

After closing the door of her house, she picked up the package lying on the ground at the height of the doorbell and descended the two steps of the veranda. She emptied the contents of the package roughly in front of the small shed in front of the fence. She bent down and looked inside the shed. It was empty. She folded the top of the package and placed it next to the shed. then jogged slowly towards the sidewalk and crossed to the other side, continuing her path through the trail in the forest.

Apart from the sound of the dried leaves crushed under her feet, there was no other sound. Green trees stretched from both sides as if trying to cover the blue sky. After running for a while, she looked at her watch. It was approaching eight o'clock. She changed her direction and plunged into the midst of the trees.

Suddenly, she heard a rustling sound and looked toward the source of the sound. The sound came from behind the bushes. She advanced towards the bushes with heavy steps, bringing her right hand to the level of her waist. Breathing rapidly, she leaped behind the bushes and pointed the knife in her hand. But there was nothing there. She slowly put the knife back in its sheath and wiped the sweat off her forehead with her other hand. She turned back in the direction she came from and resumed running at the same pace.

As she approached her house, she heard shouts and accelerated her pace because she recognized the voice.

“You damn dog! Stay away from my garden!”

The woman went to the man who was shouting at the black dog in front of her house.

“Is there a problem, Mr. Sapkon?” the woman asked and caressed her dog's head.

“A problem? The same problem I've been dealing with for the past six months! Your dog, Mss. Anton, is ruining my garden!”

Ms. Anton leaned forward and looked at Sapkon's garden.

“I don't see any problem.”

“But if I hadn't intervened, it would have trampled everything!”

“I really don't have time for this. Come, my dear, let's go home,” Mss. Anton said as she stroked her dog's head and stood up, walking towards the door of her house. Halfway there, the dog left its owner to eat and dashed towards its bowl. The woman picked up the newspaper in front of the door and entered her house.

After placing the newspaper on the countertop, she retrieved the vegetables from the refrigerator and placed them inside the blender. While the machine whirled, transforming the contents into a smooth puree, her attention was caught by a newspaper article with a striking black headline. With one hand operating the blender, she picked up the newspaper and unfolded it. The headline “MR. DORSON ELECTED MAYOR” prominently adorned the front page.

Pouring the vegetable juice into a glass, she made her way to the sitting room. She went directly to the shelf, walking between the sofas. Her hand ran through the books and chose one. With her breakfast in hand, she settled onto the couch, engrossed in her reading while occasionally taking sips of her drink.

Just as she finished her last sip, the doorbell rang. The doorbell rang again which made Mss. Anton sigh. She placed her book facedown on the couch and headed towards the door.

As she opened the door, the ringing ceased, revealing a plump man with thinning hair standing before her. He held files tightly under one arm and carried a white box in his other hand.

“Why are you here?” she inquired.

“Aren't you going to let your father in, Rose?” the plump man replied, Rose stepped back and gestured inside.

The man took a seat on the first chair at the table behind the couch in the living room. He placed the file on the table and handed it to Rose.

“As always, you're here for duty,” Rose remarked, attempting to hide her nerves, as she accepted the file. Meanwhile, her father opened the box.

“This morning, Martin Hugo was found dead a few kilometers from your house. Jason retrieved the footage from the crime scene after the forensic report,” the man stated, retrieving a pink sugar-coated donut from the box and patiently waiting for Rose to find the pictures. Once she had them in her hand, he took a bite of the donut and continued, “He had over ten visible cut marks on his body. The killer made his face unrecognizable. According to Jason, there have been a few similar deaths recently. All the victims were in their forties to fifties. We seem to have a creature that preys on the elderly. Interestingly, some individuals have gone missing in the same forest.” Another bite of the donut. “What do you think?”

“Jason may be right. After all, it's his area of expertise. It should be reliable, shouldn't it?”

“No. You're the expert, not Jason.”

“The distinct scars were clearly inflicted to drain the victims' blood. Some tribes sacrifice not only souls but also blood,” Rose remarked, glancing at her father, who had just taken the last piece of the donut. His gaze lingered on the box, which he then turned towards Rose.

“Would you like some?”

“You never listen, do you? You know what, forget it. I'll take care of the investigation as soon as possible.”

“That's my girl! It was pleasant chatting with you, but I have important matters to attend to at the library.”

“Then I won't keep you any longer. Send someone for the body tomorrow,” Rose said, as her father rose from the chair and made his way towards the door. Once Rose closed the door behind him, she let out a sigh. She ascended the staircase at the corridor's end and reached the upper floor. Adorning herself in sleek black trousers and a deep crimson shirt, she proceeded to the house's garage. A motorcycle adorned with a bright metallic finish stood prominently in the center of the garage.

Rose picked up her black leather jacket hanging on a hook near the garage entrance. After getting on her motorcycle, she put on her jacket and zipped it up to her collar. She secured her helmet on the handlebars and used the remote control from her jacket pocket to open the garage door. As the door slid open, she straightened her jacket with a quick movement. With determination, she maneuvered her motorcycle out of the garage and into the outside world.

Traffic was busy. For some reason, everyone was trying to speed east of the city, but the cars were moving slowly. Rose had no such problem. The speedometer was steadily increasing and the engine was passing between cars in sharp movements.

Gradually, the motorcycle's rumble faded until it finally fell silent. Rose parked her bike and got down on the sidewalk. When she looked up, there was a three or four-story building. On the bottom floor was a café. Rose entered the café.

As the door swung open, a bell chimed overhead, drawing the attention of an elderly woman who had gathered her silver hair into a neat bun behind the counter. She glanced towards the entrance, spotting Rose, and warmly extended her arms.

“Darling, welcome!” she exclaimed, embracing Rose affectionately.

“Hello, mom,” Rose replied, reciprocating the embrace.

“Would you like something to drink?”

“Actually, I need your help.”

“Is that so? Then come with me,” Rose's mother responded, unlocking the door labeled “staff only.” She led her daughter inside, gently guiding her through.

Once inside, Rose's mother locked the door and turned to look at the stack of boxes behind her. They were blanketed in dust, veiled by intricate spider webs. Rose handed her mother the file, and Mrs. Anton gingerly opened it, inspecting its contents.

"I assume we have a Barghest problem. Isn't it?" Rose remarked.

"Darling, without a doubt, this is a Barghest. Just examine these claw imprints. However, I haven't heard anything about the age range. Maybe it's something about the guy being cursed."

"I was thinking the same."

"In that case, why did you come here?"

"Because I have nothing that can kill the creature entirely. But I am sure that you do."

Rose's mother pulled one of the closed boxes from the warehouse in front of her. She opened it, and dust flew and spread everywhere. She rummaged inside. The sound of metal clashing against each other came from inside the box. Then her mother moved on to the second dusty box. When she couldn't find what she was looking for in that one either, she opened the third one and rummaged through it. After a short while, she turned to Rosa with a satisfied voice. She was holding a gold chain with a globe on the end, surrounded by various shapes and symbols.

"It has been years since I've used this stuff. But you are lucky. I found one."

"It's only enough for two or three bullets but still thank you, Mom." Rose said as she smiled and picked up the orb with the chain, unfastened the chain, and put it around her neck.

"Don't use the potion for bullets, honey, unless you're good at aiming. Do you know where to find the Barghest?"

"They were found dead in the woods near my house. So Barghest's lair is probably there somewhere. According to Jason, there's an old house. A house that was abandoned a few years ago. It's the perfect place for the Barghest we're looking for."

"Who are you going on the mission with?"

"I will go alone."

"Alone? Have you lost your mind, Rose? In the past, you had Nathaniel as your partner, someone to watch your back, but now..." She seemed worried after she heard the word. Looking her daughter's face with the eyes which are filled with fear.

"Don't worry mom. The creature will be surprised." Said Rose to make her mother relax a little bit. But of course, wasn't enough.

Rose got off her bike, took off her helmet, and entered the house. She threw her jacket on the couch, hurried upstairs, and went to her room. She opened the large wardrobe opposite the bed and shoved the clothes on the hangers to one side. A dark green bag appeared among the clinging clothes. Rose took the bag and put it on her bed. unzipped the zipper. At the top, there was a short sword in its sheath. She picked it up and unsheathed it. twirled it around and

inspected the sword. She ran her fingers over the silver rose engraving under the hilt and put it back in its scabbard and tossed it next to the bag. After briefly glancing at the weapons, she picked up a silver pistol and attached it to the waistband of her trousers. Rose closed the zipper back and put the bag back. That was enough for her. She distributed the clothes on the coat rack.

Holding the sword in its scabbard, she went downstairs, adjusted her belt, and slung it over her shoulder. She went outside and got on her motorcycle parked in front of the door. Just as she was about to put on her helmet, she saw her black dog running out of her neighbor's yard into her own. Right after that, she saw Mr. Sapkon chasing her dog, cursing at it.

“Ms. Rose, I can't take it anymore! Your dog...”

“How old are you, Mr. Sapkon?” Rose inquired, raising an eyebrow quizzically. She didn't care what did her dog did to the yard.

Mr. Sapkon raised his eyebrows, trying to understand the reason. “I...me? Forty-seven. Why do you ask?” Mr. Sapkon didn't notice the fist coming at his face. Even if he did, he didn't seem to be able to do anything about it.

Rose quickly drove her motorcycle deeper into the forest. She was traveling fast along an open path. Straight ahead, old Sapkon, his hands and arms bound, was slowly waking up. By the time Rose stopped her motorcycle, he was already awake. She lowered him down, grabbed the rope and pulled him along. They started to move through the trees on the narrowing road. Mr. Sapkon was trying to say something, but the piece of cloth stuffed in his mouth prevented him from being understood.

It was a few hours before dark. Rose kept noticing that time was running out. She pinned Mr. Sapkon's back against the tree and tied him to it with the thick rope she had taken from the box on the back of her bike. When she was sure it was tight, she removed the piece of cloth from the teary-eyed man's mouth. And as soon as she removed it, he asked, “Why... Why are you doing this?” asked Mr. Sapkon. This time he could not hold back his tears.

"There are things I cannot tell you. I apologize. See you soon." Rose took the piece of paper out of her jacket pocket and started walking. As she walked, she unfolded it. Suddenly, she heard Mr. Sapkon screaming for help.

After a while the screaming stopped. Rose knew the creature had taken Sapkon. She had to find the house before the creature did. She quickened her steps. And fast steps turned into running. She tried to go as fast as she could. She ran through the trees, jumping to avoid tripping over the roots of the trees sticking out of the ground.

She was out of breath. She put her hands on her knees and saw the sky turning red. She straightened her back. When she looked across, she could see the wooden structure, albeit in patches, between large tree trunks. She took a deep breath and started running towards the trees.

She was standing in front of an old house with broken windows and a broken door with pieces of wood falling from the walls. To her right was a well with a few pieces knocked over. On the other side, a swing made of creaking chain and wood swung slowly. And from

inside came a momentary scream. It was gone as quickly as it had come. Rose started walking towards the door of the house. She gripped the gun at her waist and brought it close to her face. With her other hand she held the gold chain around her neck and lifted the glass orb. The transparent orb changed color as Rose took a step, as if blood was dripping into it.

She left the orb dangling around her neck and pushed the door with her hand. The door creaked open louder than a swing and the hinges broke. Rose cursed silently as the door crashed to the floor with a loud thud and shattered into several pieces. It was worse inside than it looked from the outside. Spiders had invaded and crawled all over the rotten wood. There was a stench of carrion inside that didn't come out. It seemed to envelop the whole house. It was a disgusting smell. Rose entered the house, taking careful steps with her gun.

She pointed her gun at what she thought was speeding behind her. There was nothing. She turned toward the door opposite her. She stopped and stared at the closet a few feet away. She changed her direction and headed for the table. She saw the photo, dusty and cobwebbed, tied to the table and the bookcase behind it. As much as she hated spiders, she cleaned the web with her hand. The picture showed a man, a woman and two girls. She slowly put the photo back.

Rose was unlikely to launch a sneak attack as the worn, rotting wooden floor squeaked. Rose tried to move as slowly as possible, but every step were making an annoying sound.

In another room, a large white triangle was drawn on the floor. There were circles at the three ends. Inside each was a different symbol. In the center of the triangle, old Sapkon, stiff with fear, was curled up on his side, crying.

"Mr. Sapkon. Let's get you out of here." Rose said, pulling out her knife with her free hand. She quickly cut the ropes from Old Sapkon's hands and feet. Taking him by the arm, she helped him up. Mr. Sapkon looked at Rose as if he didn't understand anything. Rose just led him with quick steps to the exit. As soon as Sapkon was out of the door, he started running. "Wrong way!" Rose shouted and gestured in the right direction. At a loss for what to do, the man did as he was told and quickly changed direction. The moonlight in the darkening sky illuminated Rose's face as the old man disappeared from sight. "Now we begin," Rose said and went back to the log cabin.

There was nothing but light seeping into the house through the broken wood. Rose took a lantern from her jacket pocket. Shining it around, she made her way to where she had found Sapkon.

She could hear her heart beating rapidly. Even though she had come into the room without any trouble. She shone the flashlight on the symbols drawn on the floor. In the center of the triangle, in the space occupied by Sapkon, was another symbol. Rose shone the light on the symbol first. Then she got closer. She ran her hand over the symbol drawn in a dark color. She felt the stickiness on her hand and when she lifted it, she smelled the faint smell of iron. The symbol was covered in blood. She shone the flashlight into the circles in turn. They were also covered in blood. The only difference was that the white symbols were drawn over the dried blood.

He stood up and ran the flashlight along the walls. Quickly she turned it to the creaking floor. There was no one in sight. She continued on her way, shining the flashlight around. The wooden floor went dark for a short time and the light came back on. A second time the lantern's light went out and illuminated. Then it was completely dark. Rose tapped the dying lantern several times, but it was useless. Cursing, she put the lantern back in the pocket she had taken it from.

She slowed her steps and stopped. She listened. The creature was wheezing and breathing rapidly. The sound from all around of her was getting louder and louder. It was coming closer. Rose quickly turned around and began firing at the source of the sound. As the source of the sound moved around Rose, she twisted her body in fear and fired the gun.

First the growling stopped. Then the sound of bullets. And Rose sighed. It occurred to her that normal bullets don't kill the creature, they only slow it down.

Rose quickly turned around. About a meter and a half high, she saw two blood-red eyes staring angrily at her.

"Don't move!" Rose said, hoping the creature still understood the words.

The red eyes rose slowly, creaking the floor. Light filtered in through the broken glass and splintered wood on the left wall, illuminating the black fur of the creature on its feet. The two-and-a-half-meter creature's molars, two extending upwards and two downwards at the end of its lion's mouth, did not fit in its mouth. Behind its long pointed ears, fluffy black fur fell halfway down its back. The tips of its long fingers were covered with nails as sharp as knives.

Rose saw the creature in full view and pulled the trigger. At the sound of the trigger, she realized she had completely used up her bullets. The creature must have realized it too, for it let out a sound somewhere between a howl and a roar. It was a sound that awakened Rose, who felt like she had seen a ghost. She quickly grabbed the chain around her neck and pulled with all her might. As pieces of the shattered chain flew everywhere, she grabbed the remaining chain and hurled the orb at the creature. The creature who smelled the danger, stopped its noise. It snarled angrily, baring its fangs in a threatening gesture. The horrible face faded into darkness along with the sound as the moon was obscured by a curtain of clouds.

The creature seemed to be gone. But even if Rose was sure of that, she couldn't leave the creature unhunted. She had to finish her mission. She reached for the magazine in the inside pocket of her jacket and stopped. The bullets weren't doing anything to the creature. She had to use the thing inside the sphere to do it. She tried to look with the orb at the point where the broken chain was connected. She couldn't see much. But finally she found the spot by touch and removed the part of the orb with the chain.

She must have realized she didn't have time to put it in the bullets, so she reached behind her back and unsheathed her sword. She began to pour the blood-red liquid onto her sword. She swirled it around, turning the sword until she was sure it was coated all over. When the sword was completely coated, Rose lifted it up and tried to see, just barely.

Little by little, the sound of wood from far away filled the moldy house. It was coming from the entrance of the house. "You can't escape me!" Rose said in a low voice and realized how ridiculous it sounded when she said it out loud. She crossed her sword and moved towards the door.

She scanned the area with her eyes. As much as she could see. Gradually she could hear the creaking sounds better and better. A second creak followed behind her. Rose froze. There were two source of the squeaking sound.

“Idiot Nate! Where are you when I need you?” she said in a voice only she could hear and decided to be the defender instead of the attacker. They were getting close from both ways.

She turned sideways in the room she was in and started walking backwards. She could secure her back. They were approaching from left and right. As she backed up she bumped her back against the wood which is opened after it creaked. She stepped inside and kept walking backwards. Until she tripped and fell backwards.

Her back was very sore. Groaning in pain, she got up from the steps where she had hit her back. For a few seconds the silence of death surrounded her. And then it was broken again by a loud creaking. Rose climbed the steps quickly. She seemed unconscious. She was stunned. The railing swayed so much that Rose was sure it would break off at the root and she would fall, but it didn't.

The upstairs was smaller than the downstairs. The ceiling got shorter from the middle to the ends. There was nowhere to hide in the attic.

The railing swayed. She climbed slowly. This gave Rose an advantage. As she slowly backed up, she thrust her sword forward. She wanted to be ready when the creature came out. As she stepped back, she heard the boards creak with tension. That made her stop. It didn't move, but it sounded. The boards splintered and the claw grabbed her foot. The creature pulled Rose down with all its might. Rose hit her head on the broken floor and then crashed to the ground.

Rose could feel her throbbing head bleeding as the creature growled in rage. The creature looked at Rose with its red eyes and raised its claw. Rose dodged the claw coming at her, rolling to the side at the last moment. She stood up, supported by the table in front of her. She put one hand behind her head. Her hand was red and sticky wet by her blood. Her only chance was to attack. And then she realized. She didn't know where her sword is.

Now running away was the most logical idea she could think of. She spun around quickly and found her way out. But the creature had no intention of letting her. It swung its claw swiftly. Rose ran her hand over the table beneath her, grabbed the first thing that came to hand and tried to swing the claws that came at her like knives. It broke into two pieces in her hand, but she managed to dodge it.

Rose noticed the bulge in her pocket and threw the glass orb at the creature. The creature recoiled and then realized that the orb was empty. By this time Rose had run as far as she could. She was standing in front of the closed door of the house. Before she could even take a step, the creature pounced on her.

Rose hit the ground, screaming curses and trying to attack the creature standing over her. But the creature grabbed both of her hands with its sharp claws. It snarled, baring its teeth. Angrily, it tilted its head to the side and opened its foul-smelling mouth wide. Slowly it bent down to take a bite out of Rose's face. Rose turned her head to the side in disgust as

drool dripped down Rose's face. She struggled, trying to shake the creature off her. She could do nothing.

She felt the warmth in her stomach that followed the disgusting sound. And the creature collapsed on top of Rose.

"I was mistaken about the age. I guess it was just a coincidence," Said the man in the suit standing. In his hand he held Rose's sword, washed in the creature's blood. "But... I was right about other things. I even found the lair of the creature. You are welcome Mss. Anton."

"I was just about to handle it by myself, Jason." Rose said breathlessly as she threw the creature off her.

Jason held out his hand to Rose, but she was already standing up. Jason handed the sword to its owner.

"I found this upstairs. I guess its belongs to you." Said Jason with his annoying smile.

"It was you all along."

"I don't understand."

"Why did you come, Jason? New mission? Was Dad too lazy to come this time. Or did he think I wouldn't be up to the task?" She immediately changed the topic.

"I know you like hard missions, after all, you are Mr. Anton's daughter. The honored des..."

"Get to the point, Jason!" She interrupted him. "Cut the showoff."

After he exhale deeply "The Parchment revealed itself." Said with a little smile.

"Oh, my God!" Rose exclaimed excitedly. "Why didn't you say so in the first place? ? I'll start right away! No file this time?"

"Slow down, Rose. Be at the library tomorrow morning. I'll go and call the other members."

"Other members? Who are they?"

"You don't want to spoil the surprise, Rose."

"All right, first, let's get this corpse to your car and take it to the library."

"I'd love to, Rose, but you were about to handle it." Jason made one of his fake laugh. "Leave the body here. Mr. Anton will probably send someone to pick it up." His pointy finger rose. "Also who knows what kind of torture he would do to me if I put that bloody corpse in his car! I have to go. Everyone has to be back in time for tomorrow morning." Said Jason and opened the door and went out. A seventy-two Chevrolet Corvette was waiting for Jason in front of the house. He got into the car.

"Is it..."

"Yeah, Rose, Nate's car." Said man with a great joy.

As Jason's car sped away, Rose sheathed her sword and slid her gun into her waistband. Slowly she made her way through the trees. She felt like she was going to collapse and fall asleep at any moment from exhaustion. Sometimes she held on to the trees and tried not to fall.

And here was her bike right in front of her. Her legs were relieved of a great burden when she got on her bike. She gunned the throttle. The motorcycle roared while getting away from the forest.

As she opened the door to her house, her dog came in and started licking her shoes. When the door unlocked, Rose opened it wide and went inside. The dog went in with her. Rose put the gun on the counter and unbuckled the scabbard of her sword and threw it over her back. Too lazy to go upstairs, she flung herself down on the couch. She put her hand to the back of her head. The blood had dried. Her fluffy dog climbed up and settled on Rose's legs.

When Rose opened her eyes, the sun was already up. Her dog jumped down. Rose stood up and took off her jacket. She threw it on the sofa and went upstairs. She went into the bathroom opposite her room.

Rose felt better after a hot shower. Her wound wasn't really visible through her hair and there was no more blood. She opened the drawer next to her bed, took the white cloth, unsheathed her sword and gave it a good wipe. She changed the magazine in her gun and went down to her garage. She quickly lifted the blanket next to the table. Underneath was a shiny black basket like her motorcycle. She mounted the basket with the leather seat on the right side of her motorcycle. She opened the garage door and pushed her bike out while whistling. Hearing the whistle, the dog barked and came to Rose and immediately took her place. She jumped on the leather seat in the basket. Rose got on her bike and started the engine.

After half an hour of traveling, she stopped her motorcycle at the corner and got off. Her dog jumped down and came to her owner. Rose opened the door with the bell and her dog rushed inside. She ran to the cash register.

"I didn't expect to see you so soon." Said the smiling old woman, "I thought you wouldn't show up for at least a few weeks." She hugged her daughter tightly.

"I'm glad to see you too, Mom. "

"So how can I help this time?"

"I'm going on a mission and I need someone to look after my dog." Mrs. Anton bent down and petted the Rose's dog's head.

"Of course I will. But what's this mission? You don't get out of town much."

"Things are different this time. I'm going after the scroll!" said Rose with sparkling eyes. Still try to hide her excitement.

"Is that..? you know, the scroll..? Solomon's..."

"Yes!"

“That's great news!” And where is it?” Mrs. Anton asked with the same excitement of her daughter.

“I don't know anything about the mission. I'll go to the library and find out.”

“Then we'll be waiting for you here after your mission is over.” She said while she was looking to the dog. After that she hugged Rose. “I love you. You know that, right?”

“I love you too, Mom.” Rose said and she got out of her mother's arms and patted her dog's head as it sat on the floor. She tugged at the lapels of her jacket, straightened it, and set off.

She stopped in front of the building that stretched into the sky and parked her bike. She looked up at the golden “C”. It was the symbol of the company. Then she looked across the street. There was a three-story building. She crossed to the other side. One by one she climbed the stairs leading to the entrance. She looked at the big man standing by the glass door. The man buttoned up his black suit.

“Hello, Vex.”

“Welcome, Mss. Anton. Would you like me to escort you to your destination?”

“Of course.”

Vex opened the door and said, “After you.” He said. Rose walked through the door and went inside.

She saw people going about their business among the silent shelves. Some of them were people who had no idea about magic and lived an ordinary life. The other part was an employee of the library. One of them was reading a newspaper and occasionally glancing up to check who was coming in. The young people sitting at the table in the corner were doing his research and some were working. No one knew anything about each other. Rose walked through the shelves and saw the elevator. She pressed the button and the doors opened. She went inside. Vex was right behind her.

When the doors closed, Vex took his key out of his pocket. He opened the box under the buttons. There were keys with numbers from zero to nine. He glanced at Rose with a fake cough and she looked away. After six keystrokes, Vex pressed the button marked three and the elevator began to descend.

“I'm the daughter of the Boss here and you're still hiding the password from me, Vex.”

“Ms. Rose, it's my duty and I can't take even the slightest risk. Besides, Mr. Anton doesn't know the password either.”

“And do you know anything about the scroll?”

“I'm just the caretaker of the library, Mss. Anton. Jason takes care of that.” Said Vex and the elevator doors opened. “I think you can take it from here.”

“Yes, Vex. Thank you.” Said Rose and got off the elevator. As the doors closed, Rose walked down the long, wide corridor.

She opened the door. There was no one inside. She must have been early. She sat in the chair next to the round table and started to wait.